NORTH CAROLINA

The Tar Heel State



The Piedmont region of North Carolina has always known how to make something out of nothing—and make it delicious.

When Scots-Irish and German settlers pushed into the Carolina backcountry in the mid-1700s, settling along the red clay ridges between the Blue Ridge Mountains and the coastal plain, they brought with them a fierce resourcefulness that defined every aspect of daily life, including the kitchen. Land was cleared, cabins were raised, and gardens were planted—and among the first things to go into that hard-won soil was the tomato.

The tomato itself had a complicated journey to the American table. Long regarded with suspicion by European settlers who believed it poisonous, it was the farming communities of the rural South who gradually embraced it, growing it widely by the early 1800s. But Southern summers are unforgiving, and the growing season demanded patience. Gardeners watched the green fruit swell on the vine through the long humid weeks of July and August, waiting for the blush of ripeness. Inevitably, there were tomatoes that wouldn't make it—fruit picked early before the first frost threatened, or pulled green to make room for the next planting. A people who wasted nothing found a use for them.

In the farmhouse kitchens of the North Carolina Piedmont—in Alamance County, Chatham County, and the small communities tucked between towns like Asheboro and Pittsboro—women cooked over wood-burning stoves and cast iron skillets that had been handed down through generations. A green tomato, sliced thick, dredged in cornmeal seasoned with salt and pepper, and laid into a skillet of hot bacon drippings became something far greater than the sum of its parts. The cornmeal, a staple of Southern cooking with roots stretching back to the Cherokee and other Indigenous peoples of the region, gave the tomato a golden crust that crackled at the edges. The heat of the skillet softened the firm, tart flesh just enough, concentrating the acidity into something bright and savory. It was humble food, born of necessity, that somehow managed to taste like intention.

Fried green tomatoes moved through the generations the way the best Southern food always does—not through cookbooks, but through kitchens. Grandmothers taught daughters who taught daughters, each adding a small adjustment: a pinch of cayenne, a dip in buttermilk before the cornmeal, a cast iron skillet seasoned black over decades of use. By the time North Carolina's agricultural fairs and community church suppers made them a fixture of the table, no one thought of them as a recipe. They were simply part of life in this part of the world.

What you are about to make connects you to that long thread of Carolina kitchen wisdom. The moment the cornmeal hits the hot skillet and that first sizzle rises up, you'll understand why this dish has endured. Crisp, tangy, golden, and deeply satisfying—fried green tomatoes are proof that the best cooking has never needed much. Just good land, a sharp knife, and the knowledge of what to do with what you have.

FRIED GREEN TOMATOES

Few things in a Southern kitchen rival the simple joy of a fried green tomato—that perfect crunch giving way to a tart, tender center that tastes like summer itself.

Yield: 4 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 4 firm green tomatoes
- 1 cup buttermilk
- 1 large egg
- 1 cup all-purpose flour
- 1 cup cornmeal (stone-ground if possible, North Carolina style)
- 1 tsp salt
- ½ tsp black pepper
- ½ tsp smoked paprika (optional, for a Carolina twist)
- ½ cup vegetable oil, lard, or bacon drippings (traditional flavor)
- Hot sauce or remoulade, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prep the tomatoes*: Slice the green tomatoes into ½-inch thick rounds. Lightly salt and set on paper towels for 10 minutes to draw out moisture. Pat dry.
2. *Make the dredge station*: In one bowl, whisk the buttermilk and egg. In a second bowl, combine flour, cornmeal, salt, pepper, and paprika.
3. *Coat the slices*: Dip each tomato slice into the flour-cornmeal mixture, then into the buttermilk-egg mixture, and finally back into the dry coating for a crisp crust.
4. *Heat the oil*: In a large cast-iron skillet, heat oil over medium-high heat until shimmering but not smoking.
5. *Fry the tomatoes*: Fry slices in batches, 2–3 minutes per side, until golden brown and crispy. Drain on paper towels.
6. *Serve hot*: Enjoy plain with a sprinkle of salt, or with hot sauce, remoulade, or a dollop of pimento cheese.

